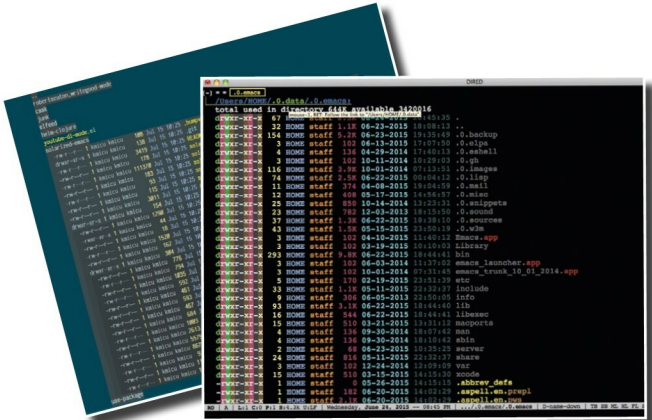


The Basics of Dired Mode in Emacs

Dired is a directory editor in GNU Emacs. It opens a buffer containing a list of directories and files to operate on. It is a 'read-only' mode and hence you cannot input any text. This article explores some of the basic commands that can be used in Dired mode.



Let us first create a sample directory, sub-directories and files that we can use for our demonstration. Open a terminal and execute the following commands:

```
$ mkdir /tmp/test/network -p
$ mkdir /tmp/test/kernel -p
$ date > /tmp/test/date.txt
$ locale > /tmp/test/locale.txt
$ cat /etc/resolv.conf > /tmp/test/network/resolv.conf
$ ifconfig > /tmp/test/network/ifconfig.output
$ dmesg > /tmp/test/kernel/dmesg.txt
```

In general, filename extensions don't have any meaning on *nix systems. Some applications do check the filename extension before using them. The extension is only for the benefit of the user, and hence you can have a filename without any extension on *nix.

Invocation

After opening GNU Emacs, you can enter Dired mode using *M-x dired*. It will prompt you for the directory to be opened in the buffer where you can input '/tmp/test'. You will see a buffer with the following contents:

```
/tmp/test:
total used in directory 24 available 146721468
drwxrwxr-x 4 shakthi shakthi 4096 Jul 3 11:36 .
drwxrwxrwt 12 root root 4096 Jul 3 11:38 ..
-rw-rw-r-- 1 shakthi shakthi 29 Jul 3 11:36 date.txt
drwxrwxr-x 2 shakthi shakthi 4096 Jul 3 11:36 kernel
-rw-rw-r-- 1 shakthi shakthi 270 Jul 3 11:36 locale.txt
drwxrwxr-x 2 shakthi shakthi 4096 Jul 3 11:36 network
```

The contents of the buffer are similar to the *ls -al* output as observed in the terminal. The files were created by the user